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HISTORY

Themes in Indian History — Part 2

Class 9

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Chapter 1

The Harappan Civilisation

The Harappan Civilisation, also known as the Indus Valley Civilisation, flourished between 2600 and 1900 BCE across the north-western part of the Indian subcontinent. It was one of the earliest urban civilisations of the world, distinguished by its planned cities, standardized weights and measures, and a sophisticated drainage system. Cities such as Mohenjodaro, Harappa, Dholavira and Lothal reveal remarkable town planning with grid layouts, citadels and lower towns. The Great Bath of Mohenjodaro, the Granary and the Dockyard at Lothal stand as testaments to advanced engineering. Seals carved with motifs of unicorns, bulls and a proto-Shiva figure suggest a rich symbolic and possibly religious life. The script, however, remains undeciphered. The decline of the civilisation is attributed to climate change, shifting river courses and declining trade.

Chapter 2

Kings, Farmers and Towns

The period after 600 BCE saw the rise of states, cities and thriving agriculture. The sixteen Mahajanapadas emerged across the Gangetic plain, with Magadha eventually consolidating power under the Mauryan empire. The introduction of iron tools, paddy transplantation and the use of coins (punch-marked) transformed the economy. Trade guilds (shrenis) flourished and long-distance trade connected the Ganga valley to Central Asia and the Deccan. Inscriptions of Ashoka spread across the empire carried royal messages of dhamma, reflecting a state policy of moral governance. The Mauryan administration, described in the Arthashastra, was highly centralised with spies, ministers and a vast bureaucracy.

Chapter 3

The Mughal Empire

The Mughal empire, founded by Babur after the First Battle of Panipat in 1526, became one of the largest centralized states in pre-modern history. Under Akbar, the empire reached its cultural and political zenith with policies of sulh-i-kul (universal peace), religious tolerance and the integration of Rajput allies. The mansabdari system organized nobility and military ranks. Mughal art, architecture and painting synthesized Persian, Central Asian and Indian traditions, producing masterpieces like the Taj Mahal and the illustrated Hamzanama. The empire's decline in the eighteenth century resulted from administrative decay, fiscal stress, regional assertions and the rise of successor states like Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad.